

the two states. Plus, in Andhra Pradesh, it is hoping that the import of Y.S. Sharmila, sister of chief minister and ruling YSR Congress leader Jagan Mohan Reddy, will boost its chances as the new president leads the party's campaign against her brother.

MODI VS WHO?

Numbers, though, are not the only challenge before I.N.D.I.A. There are also the conflicting prime ministerial ambitions of its regional leaders. Whether Mamata, Delhi chief minister and AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal or Nitish, their desire for the country's top job has been an open secret. And though the Congress may have declared that it was open to the idea of a non-Congress leader becoming prime minister in the event of I.N.D.I.A. winning the 2024 general election, Rahul Gandhi remains firmly at the centre of the party's politics. Even his ongoing Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra is being seen as an undisguised attempt to cast him as Modi's prime challenger. The yatra's timing and route have also upset the allies. Rather than make it a collectively planned mission, the Congress launched the yatra unilaterally, with Rahul as its face. "They should have done the yatra in states where they are the main rival of the BJP," says a TMC leader. "In states where the allies are the dominant players, how can the Congress expect them to be Rahul's cheerleaders? If you are in an alliance, you must play as a team." On January 30, Mamata's 'Jono Sanjog Yatra' took almost the same route as Rahul had taken the week before.

Rahul was also the catalyst in Nitish's exit. When the latter's name was proposed as I.N.D.I.A. convenor on January 13, it was Rahul who objected to it, insisting that the approval of Mamata, who was not present in the virtual meeting, be taken. To add insult to injury, Congress president Kharge was made the alliance chairperson. Mamata and Kejriwal even proposed Kharge's name as the alliance's prime ministerial candidate, hoping to kill two birds with one stone—denying both Rahul and Nitish the opportunity to project themselves as the face of I.N.D.I.A.

WHETHER THE RAM TEMPLE, RESERVATIONS FOR WOMEN, CAA OR UCC, I.N.D.I.A. CONSTITUENTS HAVE BEEN UNABLE TO COME UP WITH A UNIFIED RESPONSE

Not just Mamata and Kejriwal, most I.N.D.I.A. partners see Rahul as the weakest link in taking on Modi's seemingly teflon-coated popularity. Modi remained the clear favourite in the India Today Mood of the Nation poll in August, where 52 per cent of the respondents felt he is still the best suited to become India's next prime minister. Rahul got only 16 per cent approval.

Opposition leaders are also losing the perception battle against Modi as central agencies such as the Central Bureau of Investigation and the ED go into overdrive in their investigation of corruption charges against them. So, the ED was on Lalu and Tejashwi Yadav's case soon after Nitish took oath as CM, even as it went after Jharkhand CM Soren, and sends repeated summons to Delhi CM Kejriwal in the liquor scam though the AAP leader has made himself unavailable every time. There is also the speculation that the Modi government uses probe agencies to prevent Opposition leaders from entering into alliances that can prove electorally counter-productive for the BJP. A day after Kejriwal announced